



VIKRAM SHARMA

WAVE

With millions of vehicles clogging city roads everyday, bicycle, once considered the steed of the poor, has made a comeback even among the elite



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Bangalore Bikers' club to promote intra-city biking. The purpose of such clubs is to organise awareness programmes where they ask people to take to cycling, at least for short distances. And the road is for everyone. "You have as much right to be on the road as any other vehicle. Believe in it,"

says an advocacy document of the club.

Indeed. Dheeraj Reddy, a 21-year-old who works at Thoughtworks' studio division, recalls how he was initially apprehensive that he would not be able to bike 8.5 km to work from home. "It wasn't half as hard as I thought it would be," says Reddy. He calculated that

GET, SET, GO: Members of the Delhi Cycling Club

instead of a 45-minute ride in the car, he would be better off by cycling for 25 minutes to reach office.

Similarly, a group of people working with the Institute for Transportation and Development Policy in Delhi decided to cycle to office on an experimental basis. It started with rallies featuring about a dozen people, and organising heritage tours to areas like Shahjahanabad. Soon, says Rajendra Verma, programme coordinator of the club, they realised what they needed was to promote a cycling culture in the city. But there were problems. First, Delhi's roads are not the safest places for cyclists. The Delhi Cycling Club started organising meetings where cycling safety was discussed. Like cars, the cyclists were asked to indicate left and right turns with hand-gestures. Bums on the Saddle, for instance, asks its cyclists to wear reflective vests so that car drivers don't miss seeing them in the dark. Cyclists in Delhi constantly exchanged notes on creating carriage space in bicycles for laptops and rucksacks.

Delhi Cycling Club now considers the 5.8-km BRT lane their first achievement in the process of accepting cyclists on city roads. Go Cycling, another organisation in Bangalore, wants local businessmen to turn their unused spaces in the central business districts of the city into bicycle parking spaces, besides asking the local administration for separate cycling lanes on the roads.

A survey by Ideo, one of the world's largest innovation companies, shows that one in six people in the US is a cyclist. Largely because of their efforts to develop a series of design innovations to make bicycles look retro and uncomplicated since 2002, the sales figures pushed up at the turn of the century and prompted the US Government to allocate \$4.5 billion (Rs 19,500 crore) to cycling paths. There's no reason why India can't follow suit. It has, these days, become quite normal to find people heading for shower rooms in swanky offices with helmets, gloves and knee-guards, and settling to work after a satisfactory bicycle ride. And what's better, once you learn it, you never forget it. ■

OBESITY. BUT MOSTLY, IT'S AN ACTIVITY PEOPLE LOVE.